

‘New Detroit’ rapper makes fast work of singles success

By Owen McCarthy | Detroit News

“Rapper Lelo stood pondering Diego Rivera’s famed 360-degree mural “Detroit Industry.” The grandiose painting envelops the Detroit Institute of Arts’ central court, a testament to its enduring stewardship of fine art, its historical weight and the meticulousness of its work. Even in 2025, audiences are impelled to sit with the DIA’s art for some time.

But the folks Lelo’s music most appeals to seek a different experience, and he’s using that to craft a growing niche in the music business. Gen-Zers want to scroll, to get information fast, to move on to the next piece — an abrupt turn for a guy who studied oil painting at Albion College. While today’s artistic parameters are worrying at times for Lelo (and annoying at others), he’s opted for pragmatism.



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The 25-year-old Detroit native has managed to capture the fleeting focus of young audiences by releasing a steady, near-weekly stream of sub-2-minute singles. He employs glitchy, distorted sounds that are in vogue as Gen-Z’s standards for what’s attention-grabbing continually rise. And he posts constantly on TikTok, though he says he’d rather not.

“I ain’t never want to do that s---,” he said. But it’s a tale as old as Rivera and others at the DIA that creatives seeking success must work with the tools — and the times — at their disposal.

Musicians niftily using the internet is no new feat. Lelo exists in an era, though, where concerns that art is losing its authenticity have accelerated to a fever pitch thanks to the introduction of artificial intelligence into the creative realm.

He also stands out as a TikTok-era success story within Detroit’s storied rap scene—itselvontheupswing. As much as his music may be “internet-driven,” its Motor City ingredients are pivotal. He calls the fusion “New Detroit,” which doubles as the title of his debut full-length album, released late last month. Hometown fans are set to have their first chance at hearing it live on Sept. 14 when Lelo headlines The Shelter at the iconic St. Andrews Hall for the first time.

The Detroit sounds of church bells and lasers serving as percussion, smooth bass lines, up-tempo “ghettotech” drum grooves and flows that meander just off the beat’s meter are shot through Lelo’s single-heavy catalog. So, too, are routine references to the city’s

culture. Calling art cutting-edge is often met with skepticism, especially in the competitive, rankings-obsessed world of rap music. But Lelo’s music appears to be captivating audiences, critics and Detroit rap stalwarts alike.

“We are a tough crowd, we do not let s--- slide, we don’t just let everything through,” said Detroit DJ and producer Nick Speed. “But Lelo has created a sound that is very dope.”

An ‘internet-driven sound’

Lelo’s adaptability to audiences in the epoch of scrolling is best exemplified by the mode in which much of his music has rolled out. His debut LP follows years in which the rapper maintained a constant churn of singles, evocative of the assembly line in Rivera’s mural.

Tatiana Cirisano, a music industry analyst at MIDiA Research, said that strategy is a good way to gain traction in the “attention economy” — namely, entertainment companies’ struggle to reel in and maintain audiences given the abundance of content today.

These days, artists fear that leaving two years between album releases will all but assure audiences forget about them, Cirisano said. Lelo’s strategy of “constant releases,” by contrast, helps him stay “front of mind for people.”

But it’s not just the quantity of Lelo’s material that’s aided his ascent. *He sits at 1.5 million monthly listeners on Spotify and 65.3K followers on TikTok.* There’s also the length of his songs: They rarely eclipse 3 minutes; and several of

his most popular don’t even hit the 120-second mark, boosting their replay value.

The conciseness is “intentional” for Lelo, who himself doesn’t always prefer “listening to s--- that’s that long.” What’s more? Short songs ensure he needn’t “force (himself) to say more than what (he) felt was needed to say.”

Cirisano said the brevity is clever: **It’s “a bit more aligned with the way people experience music today, which is often in very quick hits.”**

Any discussion of Lelo’s internet-age savvy, though, is incomplete without mentioning the music itself. Lelo’s publicist, Isaac Fontes, described it as an “internet-driven sound.”

Take, for example, 2024’s “Encore,” a blistering affair that clocks in at 1:39. At its outset, a haphazard mirage of sound effects — dogs barking, ammunition shells hitting the ground, money-machine beeps, and unintelligible whispers — plays over a busy instrumental. It’s complete with an eerie, high-pitched piano sample on loop, a glitchy hi-hat pattern, and a booming, distorted 808 bass that makes perfectly intact speakers sound on the fritz.

Standing in the Great Hall of the Detroit Institute of Arts, Lelo said with a slight grin that the overblown bass wasn’t an original characteristic of the song: “I knew as soon as I heard the beat it had to be boosted. Ridiculous.” The chaos is somewhat offset by Lelo’s divergently nonchalant flow, which fluctuates between rushing just ahead of the tempo and lagging barely behind.

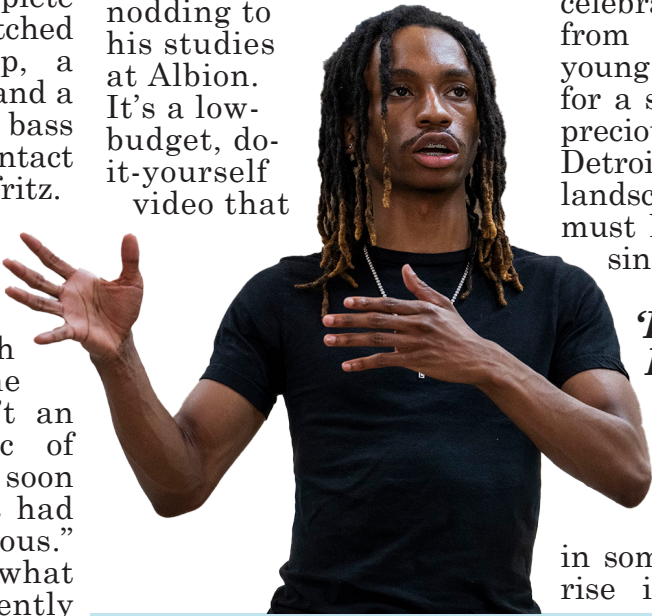
Social media prowess

Lelo learned early on that social media would be a key ingredient to succeed in music. As he recounted his ascendancy from a “starving artist,” recording himself in college, to years later having label support and enjoying glowing reviews from top music magazines, there was a telling turning point.

“I posted a few videos to TikTok and was really, really consistent about it, and one just blew up one day,” he recalled.

Among Lelo’s earliest videos to crack the algorithm on TikTok was “Stuck Up” in August 2022. It shows him rapping along to the song in a white tiled room. Closed captions of the song — with emojis standing in place for explicit language — flash across the screen. The camera sways back and forth, tracing his subdued movements.

“Shut up n---- and let me think. You can call me Da Vinci or Van Gogh, I don’t know n---- just know I paint,” he lip-syncs, seemingly nodding to his studies at Albion. It’s a low-budget, do-it-yourself video that



“Who am I, as a person who feel like I struggled, who feel like I went through something, if I wasn’t willing to use the most valuable resource in front of me, which was the TikTok?” Lelo said.

exemplifies a widely used formula for aspiring musicians in the TikTok era. It has 220.4K views on the app, and over 30K likes.

His most viral TikTok post used the same strategy. The 2024 video for “No Contempt” captures Lelo in front of a stately stone building on a cloudy night, donning a baggy gray sweater and long rosary, rapping along to the moody music. The clip, which has crossed 1 million views, feels improvised, though Lelo said there’s calculation behind his social media content.

“A lot of that is just studying — I mean, psychology sounds so like a buzzword — but really that’s what it was,” he said. “You feel me, really studying what I feel like could work to get people’s attention, what I felt scenically fit the music.” Perhaps not so coincidentally, the track the video accompanied is Lelo’s most-played on Spotify, with more than 23 million streams.

His “New Detroit” album seems to open with a celebration of his emergence from the sea of hopeful, young creatives yearning for a slice of internet users’ precious attention and into Detroit’s popular music landscape: “I see the lights I must have made it out,” he sings.

‘Indebted’ to Detroit peers

Lelo has charted his own path in the music industry. Still, he said he’s likely enjoyed the coattails, in some sense, of a broader rise in the popularity of